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CHAPTER 9

# SUPERHERO GAMING

Armed with these rules and handfuls of dice, you now have everything you need to play the game. The thing about roleplaying is that there's much more to playing the game than what you can find in any book. Like chess, go, or poker, knowing the rules is only the first step when it comes to running a roleplaying game. Unlike those games, however, you can have a lot of fun learning to play as you go, and there's very little chance of losing your house to a straight flush in the process.

## CREATING VILLAINS

Of all the characters GMs have to create, Villains are the most important. While roleplaying games have a long and venerable history of presenting Heroes with enemies to defeat, Villains are more than that. At their core, superhero stories — at least the ones that inspired this game — are about people doing the right thing. As characters who do the wrong thing, Villains provide the contrast that makes these stories work. Like Heroes, these characters represent who we can be, but they act as warnings rather than inspiration. As a result, even the lowliest Villains should be important characters in your game.

As discussed in Chapter 2, Villains are created like Heroes. The rules are the same, but you don't bother with Hero Points. You simply give these characters whatever Abilities, Talents, Powers, Perks, gear, and whatever else you want them to have. Some GMs like to know how many Hero Points their Villains would cost as Heroes, but that isn't necessary (and often leads to maniacal laughter). That aside, the main difference between Heroes and Villains is their finishing touches. Although the following rules refer only to Villains, they also apply to Foes and Extras who turn out to be not so nice (Extras who fall on the side of the angels use the heroic motivations in Chapter 2).

### VILLAIN MOTIVATIONS

Like Heroes, Villains have motivations that make them do what they do. Some are quite different from those available to Heroes, while others are closer than you might think. In the end, a Villain's motivation is not necessarily what makes them a Villain, but it is what drives them. As always, feel free to create your own villainous motivations if you can't find what you need.

#### BOND

The character has a powerful bond with someone who happens to be a Villain, so they're along for the ride. This bond can be anything from strong kinship to warm affection to deep and abiding love. Or it might be the obsessive fixation of the truly unhinged because, you know, Villains. Some characters with this motivation are just as nasty as the person they care about, maybe even more so, while others are too broken, naïve, weak willed, or young to do anything but follow their lead. A few are not really Villains at all, but they will do anything necessary to protect the person they care about.

#### CONVICTION

The Villain is pursuing what they deem to be the only reasonable course of action, or perhaps they feel obligated or duty-bound to do so. While they may not be especially evil or selfish, Villains with this motivation are often amoral and will do whatever is necessary to accomplish their goals. Archetypal characters with this motivation include the robot that gains sentience and concludes that humanity must be destroyed and the noble servant or soldier duty-bound to an ignoble superior.

#### DESPERATION

The character is a Villain because they have a problem that can't be solved any other way, or because they are being coerced into it by someone else. They might have developed powers they need to learn to control. Perhaps they were dying, and their powers are the byproduct of some magical or technological process that saved their life. Maybe they need super-powered help to save someone they love, or to protect themselves from someone or something. Someone may be using the threat of harming the character's loved ones or revealing their terrible secret to force them into villainy. Or maybe they're just trying to find someplace where they'll be accepted rather than seen as a freak or a monster.

#### INSANITY/INSTINCT

The Villain is insane and driven by delusions, or not fully in control of themselves and driven by destructive impulses, instincts, or programming. Animals, lunatics, monsters, robots, the undead, and other mindless engines of destruction often have this motivation. Villains with this motivation may or may not be sentient, and some aren't Villains in any real sense except that the Heroes must stop them. For example, an enraged bear wounded and left to die by irresponsible hunters would have this motivation.

#### MALICE

The character is motivated by sheer malice. The best of these Villains are mean and selfish, angry and entitled, or lacking in any real sense of empathy. The worst are truly evil or criminally insane: arsonists who want to watch the world burn, sociopaths who feel nothing for anyone but themselves, psychopaths who kill for the sheer joy of it, and lunatics who want people to see that life is just one big killing joke. Supernatural monsters like demons, devils, and vampires often have this motivation as well.



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### MONEY
The Villain is in it for the money. For these career criminals, villainy is just a job that pays well. This motivation covers arms dealers, assassins, bank robbers, drug dealers, hired muscle, kidnappers, mercenaries, thieves of every kind, and entrepreneurs with shady business dealings. Villains with this motivation are typically practical, caring mainly about themselves and their bank accounts. More immoral than evil, Villains with this motivation sometimes have lines they won't cross.

### POWER
The character wants to rule. Some have a lust for power, but others do so out of a sense of responsibility or manifest destiny. This is the motivation of conquerors, great military leaders with armies of henchmen willing to do their bidding. It also covers those who prefer to obtain power by more indirect means, such as by amassing extraordinary wealth, manipulating existing political systems (maybe even by running for office), or securing the power of popular opinion through mass media. These Villains will do anything to expand their reach while protecting the power they already possess.

### PROGRESS
The character will do anything in the name of progress or personal development. This is the motivation of mad geniuses willing to cast ethics aside in the name of science, single-minded explorers who will do anything to make a new discovery, and soul-corrupted sorcerers who will stop at nothing to uncover arcane secrets. While the desire for knowledge is a noble pursuit, characters with this motivation will go to any lengths to achieve this end, making them as dangerous as any zealot.

### REBELLION
The Villain refuses to play by society's rules. These characters aren't usually after money, power, or even thrills. They just don't care, or maybe they're trying to make a point. The Villains who truly don't care tend to be aimless rebels who rarely have a larger plan in mind. They take what they want and do what they want because they can. The ones who want to send a message or incite change, on the other hand, can be as calculating and strategic as anyone else. Some of these Villains are hardcore punks who've spent their lives laughing at the sheep, while others were part of the flock until they snapped, pushed too far by a supervisor, spouse, or server at a fast food restaurant.

### REVENGE
The Villain is on a quest for revenge for some real or imagined wrong committed against them or someone they love. Some of these characters are monsters, but others are sympathetic, people pushed over the edge by grief, despair, or powerlessness. While some of these poor souls can be brought back from the abyss, others are too consumed with rage to ever turn back. For them, revenge is all there is.

### THRILLS
An adrenaline junkie primarily, the character is just having fun. Of course, their version of fun involves breaking the law and putting others in danger, but they don't care about that. Villains with this motivation can seem harmless or even charming, and some in fact are, especially those who are young and immature. But the ones who should know better are often little more than self-centered sociopaths, focused on having fun regardless of how their actions hurt others.

### ZEALOTRY
The character is completely devoted to a cause or belief, whether noble or ignoble, and will cross any line in furtherance of their zealotry. Or they might espouse the twisted ideals of a particularly vile people, group, or nation. Villains with this motivation often act in concert with others who share their beliefs, sometimes even leading groups, nations, or worlds as their exemplar.

## VILLAIN GOALS
Instead of connections, Villains have **goals**, specific things they want to accomplish. While a Villain's motivation tells you what drives them, their goals explain how they intend to satisfy those drives. Some Villains will have simple unimaginative goals: get rich by robbing a few banks, make enough money working as muscle for the mob to get their ailing spouse that experimental new treatment, etc. Others will have intricate, step-by-step goals spanning weeks, months, or even years, the kind needed to bring their master plan to fruition. And many will fall somewhere between these extremes. Smarter Villains usually have more complex and well-defined goals, but that isn't always the case. At the end of the day, it all depends on the Villain, what they want to accomplish, and how they intend to get it done.

## VILLAIN METHODS
Instead of details, Villains have **methods**. This describes how the Villain operates and how far they'll go to accomplish their goals. Does the Villain prefer to act directly, or do they work through others? If they act through others, are those characters allies, subordinates, or clueless catspaws? Does the Villain operate openly, do they move in secret, or are they hiding in plain sight? Do they tend to approach challenges physically, intellectually, or socially? What are the Villain's usual tactics in combat? How do they prefer to fight, assuming they fight at all?

A Villain's methods also indicate what they are willing to do. Obviously, breaking the law isn't an issue. But what about innocents: is the Villain willing to endanger, harm, or kill innocent civilians? Do they try to avoid this at all costs? Or do they fall somewhere in between? What about those foolish enough to stand in their way? Are they treated any differently than those smart enough to cower in fear or stand aside? And when someone does attempt to challenge the Villain, do they distinguish between mundane law enforcement personnel and super-powered interlopers?


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## VILLAINOUS ORIGINS

The last element of every great Villain is their origin. As with Heroes, a Villain's origin explains who they are and how they acquired their unique abilities. The best villainous origins, however, do one more thing: they make even the worst Villain somewhat sympathetic. A thoroughly despicable Villain is fine, but a thoroughly despicable Villain the players can relate to or have sympathy for is a masterpiece! It works that way in fiction, and it works that way in the game. The most interesting Villains are those we understand, no matter how much we abhor their actions. If you can make the players (that's the *players*, not the Heroes) feel sympathy for the worst of your Villains, it will take your game to another level.

## NEMESES

There are Villains and there are **nemeses**. It's easy to think of a nemesis as nothing more than a recurring Villain that really has it out for a particular Hero, but that would be a mistake. Although they are recurring Villains, a nemesis serves a unique purpose. While most Villains exist to challenge the Heroes, nemeses exist to help define them.

A nemesis is always a dark reflection of their heroic archrival. For some, this means the two share something essential in common. They might have identical abilities and powers, backgrounds, goals, methods, motivations, origin stories, or weaknesses. These kinds of nemeses highlight the fact that people have choices. Regardless of their similarities, one of these characters became a Hero and one became a Villain. Their choices were not the inevitable result of anything they have in common; they came from within and speak volumes about who these people are.

The other kind of nemesis is one that embodies the exact opposite of something essential to their heroic archenemy. Here, the conflict between Hero and Villain reflects a larger conflict between two broader concepts, ideals, or philosophies: strength versus intellect, freedom versus order, light versus darkness, capitalism versus communism, and so on. In some cases, neither concept is inherently right or wrong; how they're pursued is what separates Hero from Villain. In others, the difference between good and evil couldn't be more obvious.

Because Heroes and their nemeses are so closely intertwined, players (not GMs) create nemeses for their Heroes. Players who aren't interested in creating a nemesis can leave this to the GM, or they can choose not to have one. The decision is entirely up to each player. Once a player creates their nemesis, that character belongs to the GM and is treated like any other Villain. GMs should follow the guidelines and suggestions a player establishes when creating their nemesis, but once created, control of the nemesis rests squarely in the hands of the GM.

## FOES

Everything discussed above applies as much to Foes as it does to Villains. Mechanically, the only difference between Foes and Villains is that Foes have less Health (usually half as much). Although Foes tend to be less developed than Villains, the difference between the two often boils down to which character has the spotlight at the moment. Many comic book supervillains have been both Villain and Foe over the years, hopping back and forth between roles depending on how central they are to the story. While this kind of flexibility isn't usually an element of roleplaying games, it's very common in comic books and easy enough to replicate in P&P by making these characters Villains in some stories and Foes in others. While perhaps not every supervillain should get this treatment, it will go a long way to ensuring that Foes are just as interesting as Villains.





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# CREATING STORIES

As mentioned earlier, a **story** is a discrete tale involving the Heroes that has a distinct beginning, middle, and end. In other games this would be called an adventure. There's no right way or wrong way to create a story. All that matters is the result. However, it can be helpful to have a process in place. This keeps you organized and gives you something to refer to when you get stuck or find yourself at a loss for ideas. To that end, the following process for creating superhero stories involves six steps: Villains, Plot, Tropes, Sacrifice, Scenes, and Trappings. Each step is discussed below.

### SUPER TIP!

***Superhero games become stale villain-of-the-week slugfests if the Heroes don't have personal lives that let them be real people as well as caped crusaders. No matter how noble, steadfast, or invulnerable the Heroes, they should always have flawed, fickle, fragile people in their lives who they care about dearly.***

## VILLAINS

Every story starts with a Villain or Villains, the main antagonists of the adventure. You don't need to know what these scoundrels are doing or why they're doing it, at least not yet. For now, all you need to do is create the Villains or select them from your pool of existing characters. The process of creating Villains has already been discussed, almost like it was planned it that way ... *diabolical!*

## PLOT

Once you have a Villain or Villains, decide on a plot. At this point in the process, the plot is just a simple phrase or sentence that describes what the story is going to be about. Most superhero plots fall into one of three categories: schemes, plans, or events. Each is described below.

### SCHEMES

A scheme is a nefarious plot the Villain or Villains intend to carry out. Most of the time, the Heroes must stop a scheme from coming to fruition. Occasionally, the scheme has already been accomplished when the story begins, in which case the Heroes have to deal with the aftermath, figure out how to repair or undo whatever the Villains have done, or both. This is probably the most common plot for a superhero story because Heroes tend to be reactive, responding only when reasonably certain that the Villains have done, are doing, or intend to do something illegal.

### COMMON PLOTS

| SCHEMES | PLANS | EVENTS |
|---|---|---|
| Acquire something dangerous | Assault or defend a location | Accidental nuclear launch |
| Assassinate a person | Build something wonderful | Accidental release of toxic gas |
| Assault or defend a location | Defeat or escape from a monster | Airplane falling from sky |
| Blackmail someone | Deliver a message | Asteroid approaching |
| Break someone out of prison | Discover a long-lost location | Avalanche, mudslide, or rockslide |
| Bribe or extort a person or group | Discredit a corrupt person or group | Bridge or building collapse |
| Build something terrible | Dismantle a criminal organization | Building fire |
| Buy, sell, or transport contraband | Dispose of something dangerous | Dam/berm collapse |
| Capture or kidnap someone | Escape from a place or situation | Earthquake and aftershocks |
| Destroy an object or location | Evolve, progress, or transform | Failure at nuclear power plant |
| Discover a long-lost location | Expose blackmail or a conspiracy | Failure at super prison |
| Discredit a noble person or group | Find and arrest a criminal | Floodwaters approaching |
| Escape from a place or situation | Find the way home | Hurricane, tornado, or tsunami |
| Establish or further a conspiracy | Forge an alliance | Interdimensional rupture |
| Evolve, progress, or transform | Gather and share information | Mass hysteria or civil unrest |
| Feed and/or reproduce | Guard or transport a person or object | Massive sinkhole |
| Forge an alliance | Overthrow a corrupt government | Oil rig fire |
| Overthrow a government | Plan and conduct a mass battle | Ships on collision course |
| Plan and conduct a mass battle | Prevent a crime from happening | Sinking passenger ship |
| Recover a long-lost object | Prove someone's guilt or innocence | Subway or train tracks destroyed |
| Rob a location | Recover a long-lost or stolen object | Tidal wave approaching |
| Steal an object | Rescue kidnap victim or missing person | Trains on collision course |
| Summon something terrible | Solve a crime or clear your name | Volcanic eruption |
| Terrorize a populace | Win a competition | Wildfire out of control |



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### PLANS
The opposite of a scheme, a plan is something the Heroes set out to do, either of their own accord or at the behest of some other person or organization. In this case, the Villains are the ones attempting to foil the plan and prevent the Heroes from accomplishing their goal. Sometimes, the reasons for this are obvious; other times, figuring out why the Villains are involved is part of the story.

### EVENTS
Events are major occurrences that the Heroes become involved in, but which can't be attributed to the Heroes or the Villains, at least not directly or not intentionally. Although Villains often become involved in these plots, they're usually reacting to or taking advantage of whatever is happening. If the event is especially catastrophic, the Villains might even put aside their differences and try to help the Heroes. After all, you can't conquer the Earth if there's no Earth left to conquer.

## TROPES
The next thing to consider when creating a story is which tropes you want to use. Tropes are narrative elements common to a genre, in this case the superhero genre. Although not necessary, tropes can help make your game feel more like a comic book. Besides, there are so many great superhero tropes to choose from that it seems a shame not to take advantage of them. You can pick from the list below or use any of the countless others we're sure to have missed.

### AMNESIA
One or more of the Heroes lose their memory for at least some portion of the story. They won't know who they are or whom they can trust. They might not even remember they have superpowers. Or they might think they're supervillains, typically because some Villain tricks them into believing this, at least until the Heroes uncover the truth thanks to their unflinching moral compasses.

### APES AND/OR DINOSAURS
The story involves apes, dinosaurs, or both. If it involves apes, they're intelligent apes, as least as intelligent and/or technologically advanced as human beings if not more so. If it involves dinosaurs, the dinosaurs may or may not be intelligent time travelers — this one can go either way.

### ATLANTIS
Whether bearing that name or another, just about every comic book universe includes an undersea kingdom hidden away from humanity for most of history. The story is going to involve this kingdom and its people in some way, whether as allies, enemies, or both.

### BACK FROM THE DEAD
The Villain of the story turns out to be an old archrival the Heroes thought was dead. Or perhaps it's an imposter. If it does turn out to be an imposter, the true Villain (again, supposedly dead) may make a brief cameo, drawn out of hiding to crush any who would dare take their name. This trope works best with a Villain the Heroes have faced in the past, ideally on multiple occasions.

### BETRAYED
*Curse your inevitable betrayal!* The Heroes are betrayed in some way by a former ally. The treacherous former ally may or may not become one of the enemies the Heroes have to defeat later in the story. The Heroes may eventually discover that the former ally was acting under duress, but it's just as likely that the former ally really was a bad guy all along. Although this trope often is used together with the Unlikely Ally trope (see below), it's almost too obvious to be worth it. Almost.

### CAPTURED
The Heroes get captured and must somehow escape their confinement. Of course, for one reason or another, their Powers won't be of any use. For a real change of pace, the story might start with the Heroes already in captivity — they might not even remember how they got there. Give each Hero 1 Resolve as a peace offering for using this heavy-handed trope.

### DEATHTRAPS
Deathtraps are the Captured trope on performance enhancers. The Heroes not only get captured; they also get placed in a deathtrap from which they have to escape. This admittedly corny trope has fallen out of favor. Honestly, if a Villain wants to kill a Hero they have at their mercy, there are easier ways than tossing them into a tank that gradually fills with water, lowering them into a vat of acid, tying them under a massive weight that will slowly crush them, etc. Plus, deathtraps tend to be most effective on Heroes who lack true superpowers (although you can get around this with power nullifiers). But if the trope fits the game, the deathtrap is a classic worth dusting off.

### EVIL DUPLICATES
The Heroes must confront their (presumably evil) duplicates in the story. These duplicates might be clones or robots meant to publicly misbehave and discredit the Heroes. They might be doppelgangers from an alternate dimension, or perhaps from a Future Gone Wrong that the Heroes need to fix. They might be mental constructs created by some cosmic entity. Or they might be something else. The specifics matter less than the fact that the Heroes will have to battle themselves.

### GRUDGE MATCH
One or more of the Villains in this story are characters the Heroes have gone up against in the past. They might have broken their way out of prison, they might have been hired by someone because of their prior history with the Heroes, they might be doing something specifically to get back at the Heroes, or their presence might be nothing more than a bad coincidence. Whatever the case, the Villains have a bone to pick with the Heroes and are itching for a rematch.


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### HERO VS HERO
The Heroes must fight other superheroes at some point during the story. This could happen for any number of reasons, often mind control, mistaken identity, or misunderstanding. To be honest, the real reason for this is that comic book fans seem to love having superheroes fight each other. Assuming the other superheroes haven't turned to the dark side, things should be cleared up and everyone should be more or less friends again by the time the story concludes.

### HOSTAGE CRISIS
The Villain takes someone hostage, ideally someone important to one or more of the Heroes. The Heroes have to rescue this person by the time the story concludes and may need to be very careful about how they do this because the Villain will use the hostage as leverage. Occasionally, the Heroes will discover that what they thought was a hostage was in fact an accomplice (see Betrayed and Willing Victim).

### INNOCENT BYSTANDERS
At least one major scene is going to take place in a location choked with so many civilians the Villains won't know what to do with themselves. If it's a battle scene, the Heroes are going to have their hands full protecting these people. If it's an investigation or a roleplaying scene, the threat of what might happen to all those innocent people will force the Heroes to stand down while the Villains cross something off their evil to-do list, escape with a hostage, gloat insufferably, or do something equally infuriating.

### THE LOST WORLD
The story takes place in some lost primeval world. It often involves protecting a tribe of peaceful — and usually attractive — natives from a different tribe of warlike — and usually less attractive — natives or protecting the lost world itself from exploitation. Occasionally, the twist is that the attractive and initially friendly natives are actually complete jerks who are using and abusing their less evolved neighbors. And sometimes, the Heroes must protect the lost world and its inhabitants from being exploited by the people who sent them there in the first place.

### MANIPULATED
The Heroes discover that they've been lied to or are being manipulated by someone they trusted, often an employer, authority figure, or Patron. This trope can be particularly effective if the Heroes all have the same Patron, and this person or organization turns out to have been lying to them or telling them half-truths. It becomes even more interesting when different Heroes have different degrees of loyalty to the Patron. This trope is just a specific version of Betrayed.

### THE MISUNDERSTOOD VILLAIN
The Villain turns out to be misunderstood rather than evil. This is often the case when the Villain is a wild animal or rampaging monster of some kind. Other common scenarios include Villains who are being blackmailed, completely unaware of the harm they're causing, or under someone else's control.

### PLOT TWIST
The Heroes learn something, or some new development occurs that either changes the goal they were originally trying to accomplish or brings a new goal into play. This new or additional goal is normally more difficult, more dangerous, or of greater consequence than the original.

### POWERLESS
The Heroes are rendered powerless for all or a portion of the story and must accomplish their goals without relying on their unique abilities. Or they could be surrounded by other people — maybe including people they know — and must pretend to be civilians for most of the story. This can make for an interesting game and a great change of pace, but don't do this too early in a series. Let the players enjoy their superpowers for a while before you strip them away.

### RELATIONSHIP
One or more of the Heroes has a significant personal relationship with someone involved in the story, often a victim or a Villain (or better yet, one of each). Even if the Villain has a secret identity, the Hero or Heroes will know or strongly suspect their true identity.

### REVERSE WORLD
The story takes place on a planet or dimension that is the mirror image of the "real" one. In that world, the Heroes are the bad guys and the Villains are the superheroes. The Heroes may need to team up with characters who are normally their enemies to fight those who are normally their allies. They might even have to fight themselves (see Evil Duplicates). This is another technique that won't work if you do it too early in a series. The players need to get to know their Heroes, the Villains, and the important Extras in their world before you turn everything upside down.

### SECRET BASE
Some part of the story involves finding, reaching, exploring, escaping from, or destroying a Villain's secret base. The base is likely to be found in a hazardous, remote, or unusual location like in the Arctic or the Antarctic, on an uncharted island, deep under the ocean, in a volcano, on a satellite orbiting the Earth or another planet in the Solar System, on the Moon, or in a parallel or pocket dimension, etc. For a change of pace, rather than being in active use, the base has long-since been abandoned.

### SECRET MISSION
Something about what the Heroes are doing must remain secret from one of the NPCs, the authorities, or the public. The Heroes might have to guard someone who can't know they're being guarded. They might be tasked with something too big or too dangerous for ordinary police. They could be saddled with a job so critical that the general public must be kept in the dark because there would be widespread panic and rioting in the streets in they knew the danger they were in. You get the idea. Whatever the case, keeping the secret is going to be easier said than done.


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### STAKES RAISED
Save the cheerleader, save the world. The Heroes learn something, or some new development occurs that significantly raises the stakes of the current story, making it that much more critical that the Heroes succeed. A common version of this trope is that what initially seems to be an ordinary crime turns out to be the first step in a Villain's larger master plan.

### STUPID HUMOR
Something about what the Heroes must do is absurd or ridiculous. If the Heroes must participate in a contest, it's going to involve something like ballroom roller skating or full-contact macramé. If they must rescue a hostage, it's going to be a magically animated Teddy Bear with a colorful vocabulary. Although these stories tend to be more lighthearted than most, this trope works best if everything else in the story remains just as serious as in any other game. The contrast is what makes this work.

### THIRD PARTY
A third party that favors neither the Heroes nor the Villains enters the story. This third party has its own agenda that may put it in conflict with the Heroes, the Villains, or both. The Heroes and Villains may even need to put their differences aside and work together against this third party.

### TIME LIMIT
Although Heroes rarely take it easy, they're really going to be racing against the clock in this story. Often, the Villain has set wheels in motion and their master plan will reach a point of no return if the Heroes can't stop it by a certain time. Occasionally, the Heroes are competing against the Villains — or maybe against a group of rival superheroes — and need to do something or get somewhere first.

### TIME TRAVEL
The Heroes have to travel to the past, the future, or both over the course of this story, or they're going to meet characters from those times, often characters related to them in some way. This trope can involve a host of time travel hijinks, from the comedic like going to the past to make sure your parents meet, to the sobering like going to the future to discover global apocalypse and ruin.

### TRUE VILLAIN
The Heroes learn something or some new development occurs that makes it evident that the original Villain is actually a cat's paw or a patsy for the true Villain, who is usually more dangerous than the original. The Heroes often have to defeat the original Villain before this is revealed.

### UNDERCOVER WORK
The Heroes have to go undercover, often but not always among Villains. Should that be the case, the Heroes may get to see a different side of Villains they usually can't stand, and might even grow to empathize if not actually like some of them. As with several of the tropes described in this section, this one works best after the players and their Heroes have gotten to know — and ideally really grown to despise — a particular Villain or group of Villains.

### UNLIKELY ALLY
The Heroes encounter an unexpected or unlikely ally, possibly even a Villain, who will help them in some way, at least in this story. In fact, it's possible that this unlikely ally is the one who comes to the Heroes for help in the first place. This unlikely alliance may be a one-time thing, or it could signal the beginning of a different relationship between the ally and the Heroes (a Villain who becomes a Hero, for example, which happens all the time in comic books).

### UNSTOPPABLE FOE
The Heroes face an enemy they can't defeat. This could take the form of a being from beyond who whisks them away to do battle for its amusement, an ancient cosmic entity that must consume planets to survive, a massive invasion force they can't hope to withstand, or something similar. The Heroes will have to use diplomacy, cunning, or guile against this opponent, or they may simply need to flee for now until they can find a way to overcome this enemy in a future story.

### WILLING VICTIM
Someone the Heroes are attempting to rescue or save is in league with the Villains and will betray or attempt to thwart the Heroes to the best of their ability. This technique works best if the victim is someone important to one or more of the Heroes, especially if the supposed victim turns out to be the major Villain of the story. This is just a specific version of the Betrayed trope.

### WORLD GONE MAD
The world is not as it should be. Perhaps it's been transformed into a land resembling something out of medieval fantasy, perhaps it's become a post-apocalyptic wasteland, perhaps the machines have taken over, or perhaps it's as one would expect if things had worked out differently at some critical juncture in history. The Heroes may or may not realize that things are not as they should be, although the players sure will. This trope can serve as the backdrop for a single story or for a story arc that spans multiple adventures and culminates with the Heroes doing whatever they must to return things to normal.

## SACRIFICE
Personal sacrifice is probably the most ignored or forgotten element of the superhero genre, at least when it comes to roleplaying games. This is unfortunate because it's more important than just about anything else. Sacrifice is what makes a superhero game feel like a superhero game instead of a game about people who just happen to have powers. It's the greatest source of conflict and drama in comic books, because sacrificing yourself for others is what it means to be a hero (super or not).

Typically, the kind of personal sacrifice we're talking about occurs when a story presents a Hero with a choice between doing the right thing and doing the easy thing. Inevitably, the right thing is


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the heroic thing — dangerous, selfless, and probably thankless. The easy thing, on the other hand, is what the Hero would rather do. It's comfortable, safe, and often in the character's best interest. But it's not what a hero would do. Heroes who do the right thing often suffer personally or professionally and must live with the fallout of ignoring their relationships, careers, etc. Occasionally, the sacrifice involves only the character's life as a superhero, like having to choose between saving a friend or saving a building full of strangers, or having to resist killing a Villain who did something terrible to the Hero or someone they love.

*For example, what do you do when a supervillain attacks the city on your wedding anniversary? What if it's not a supervillain, just an ordinary bunch of bank robbers? Can't the cops handle that? What if you and your spouse are going through a tough time? Don't you deserve a chance to fix things? With everything you do for the city, don't you deserve a chance to be happy too?*

This type of drama gives characters a chance to truly be heroic, not because they have incredible abilities, but because they do the right thing, even when it requires great personal sacrifice. By adding these moments of sacrifice to the game, GMs give players the opportunity to roleplay what it means to be a true hero, to put some larger goal or greater good ahead of themselves. Or it lets them roleplay what it means to betray their principles, to give in to fear or pressure, to put themselves ahead of others, because sometimes even superheroes falter. Either way, these moments underscore the fact that this isn't a game about adventurers with powers, this is a game about superheroes.

## USING SACRIFICE

Not every Hero should have to deal with personal sacrifice in every story. While comic books may be spandex-clad soap operas, they're fiction and this is a game. GMs would need to have too much control over the story to keep creating opportunities for this kind of drama in their games. Instead, moments of personal sacrifice should usually be reserved for stories that spotlight an individual Hero and should involve only that Hero. In fact, the GM and the player can work together to come up with the conflict that triggers this drama, typically something involving the Hero's motivation, connections, or details.

Sacrifice should unfold over the course of a story in roughly four parts. In the first, the GM should introduce the conflict in a brief scene that involves only the Hero, or as part of a larger scene involving several Heroes. In the second part, something should happen to ramp up the tension, making it clear that there is no easy way for the Hero to resolve the situation. The Hero may seriously consider doing the wrong thing at this point in the story, but something will prevent this from happening. In the third part, which happens at some critical moment in the story, the Hero must make a hard choice. And in the fourth and final part, the Hero must deal with the consequences of their decision.



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*For example, one way to handle the anniversary dinner example above would be as follows. In one scene, the Hero and their spouse have an argument or tense exchange indicating that there's trouble (even better if this is an ongoing issue from a previous game). In a second scene, there might be an even bigger argument. Or you might have an interlude with another character (maybe while shopping for groceries) where the Hero talks about how they hope to mend fences at the anniversary dinner. The third scene happens on the way to dinner if not right in the middle of it, right when things are starting to look hopeful, duty calls, and the Hero has to make their choice. And the final scene involves the consequences of whatever choice the Hero made — a cold shoulder at home, or a news report about civilians being injured or even killed during the bank robbery the Hero decided to ignore.*

### MOOD AND SACRIFICE

In games with darker moods, there's no magic solution. Heroes who do the right thing and decide to take on the Villains, rescue the hostages, or save the world will suffer due to their choices. They might get seriously injured, their friends might cut them off, they might get fired, their spouse might leave them, their enemies might bribe or extort their way out of prison, and so on. In short, their good deeds won't go unpunished. Heroes who choose not to make the necessary sacrifice will avoid these repercussions, but the guilt will be difficult to bear as they learn the terrible things that happened because they didn't do anything about it. If they didn't feel guilty, they wouldn't be superheroes.

In games with lighter moods, it's assumed the Heroes will probably make the right decision, albeit after some soul searching. Of course, players are free to make whatever decision they wish. More importantly, the consequences of these decisions are typically temporary and less severe in games with lighter moods. Heroes who do the right thing might wind up wearing a cast for a scene or two, hurting the feelings of someone close to them, getting into hot water at work, and so on, but the consequences they face won't be too bad or last too long. Similarly, Heroes who choose to act unheroically will probably fall into a short-lived funk, often until fate presents them with an opportunity to redeem themselves (this will almost certainly happen sooner rather than later in such games).

### RESOLVE AND SACRIFICE

You don't need rules to bring the idea of personal sacrifice into your games. However, if you want to reinforce the impact of this drama on a Hero, use the following optional rules. If a Hero does the right thing, they immediately earn 1 to 3 Resolve (roll one die and halve the result). However, at some point during the next story, the GM brings the consequences of that decision into the game, and the Hero will immediately lose 2 to 4 Resolve (roll as above but add 1 to the result) as they deal with the fallout of their decision. If a Hero does the easy thing, they immediately earn 3 Resolve. However, from that moment on, all uses of Resolve costs twice as much as usual — guilt is not an easy thing to deal with — especially for a superhero. This lasts until the Hero finds redemption by doing something truly heroic.

## SCENES

At this point you have your Villain or Villains, a plot, and a few tropes, and you've decided whether to throw some moment of personal sacrifice into the story. It's now time to create your scenes. Before we get to that, we should probably say a word two about scenes themselves.

There are three basic kinds of scenes: action scenes, investigation scenes, and social scenes. **Action scenes** involve fights, chases, and other kinds of, well, action. **Investigation scenes** involve gathering information in various ways such as by exploring the world, interacting with NPCs, researching online or (heaven forbid) in actual books, and scouring locations for clues. Scenes in which players have to solve riddles or puzzles are usually investigation scenes. Social **scenes** focus on interpersonal interaction between characters. Interludes (discussed later in this chapter) are usually social scenes. Although often played purely for roleplaying purposes or to provide background information, social scenes can also involve challenges to overcome or information to uncover. It's just that these things are accomplished by interacting with other characters in social scenes. Most stories should include a mix of all three types of scenes, although how much of each depends on your group. Some folks prefer lots of action, others enjoy solving mysteries and puzzles, and others want an abundance of freeform roleplaying. As with everything else, salt to taste.

As you create each scene, include only as much detail as you need to feel comfortable. This varies by GM, by story, and by scene. An experienced GM might be comfortable running a complex story with only sketchy details, while a novice may want to do a lot of prep work for each scene. Both approaches are perfectly fine, as is anything between these extremes. However, there are a few guidelines that apply to just about everyone. You should always have the mechanical stuff worked out ahead of time, things like character stats and rough maps of areas where combat may occur. You should also know who your NPCs are, what they're like, and what they want (their motivations). Beyond that, do only as much prep work as you need to run a great game.

### THE CLIMAX

The climax is the big finale, where the Heroes and the Villains go at one another in a no-holds-barred winner-takes-all showdown. Although it might seem strange, this is probably the first scene you should create. You need to know exactly where the Villains are headed, what their plans are, and what the culmination of their nefarious plot will look like. This is going to be the scene where you bring out the big guns and throw everything you have at the Heroes. The climax is usually an action scene, specifically a fight scene, but this doesn't always have to be the case. Some Villains may have to be outsmarted rather than outfought, while others may need to be convinced of the error of their ways. And some climaxes will involve two or more of these elements. Whatever the specifics, the challenges the Heroes face in this scene should be the toughest the story has to offer. By the time this scene is done, the players — not the Heroes, the *players* — should be sweating.



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Despite everything above, don't force the climax. If your players come up with a way to thwart the Villain before you reach the climax of the story, let them. Don't steal their victory, assuming they'll prefer the climax you had in mind. Trust us, they won't. They'll just feel cheated and disempowered when they realize their idea should have worked. Instead of railroading your players toward the grand finale you envisioned, save your ideas for a future story, and give them the victory they deserve.

### THE HOOK

The hook is the first scene of the story, and it's usually the second scene you create. Once you know where the story's going, the next thing to decide is how the Heroes get dragged into it. A good hook does three things: gets the players interested, tells them what they need to know, and draws the Heroes into the action — hooks are usually action scenes. These are listed in order of importance. Player interest is paramount. If the players aren't excited about the story right from the start, you're in for a long night. While the first scene of the story should also tell the players what they need to know and pull their Heroes into the action, these things are less critical. If your players are interested, they'll find a way to get their Heroes involved in the story, and they'll forgive you for any information you forgot to share. Get them hooked (see what we did there?) and everything else will follow.

Most hooks occur at the beginning of the story. The Heroes are doing their own thing when someone or something comes along and pulls them into the action. This gives the players all the information they need right at the start. When starting a story at the beginning, throw the Heroes into the action as soon as possible. Never start a game with a painfully long monologue. Any introduction that demands more than five minutes of narrative on your part is probably a bust; the players will lose interest before the game even begins. Get the story moving and the players playing as soon as possible.

If you want to try something different, start a story smack in the middle of a fight or a chase scene, something serious and dangerous. Give your players just enough information to understand what they need to accomplish, but not why. Then, once the scene is over, take a moment to explain what the Heroes were doing and why they were doing it. While this kind of hook does involve some railroading, it's a great way to get the Heroes into the action and the players interested right away; few things make players sit up and take notice like putting their Heroes in danger. When starting a story like this, you have to take extra care to ensure that whatever you say happened before the hook makes logical sense within the game and is true to the Heroes. If your description of what happened before the story begins has the Heroes doing something stupid or out of character, your players won't buy into your idea.

### THE BODY

Once you have your hook and your climax, you then create the other scenes that make up the body of your story. Don't try to create a whole story all at once. Instead, just consider where the story might go after the hook, see where your imagination leads you, and create that scene (or scenes if the story can go in multiple directions). Then move on from there, thinking only about the scenes that might follow the ones you already created, remembering that they eventually need to lead to the story's intended climax. While by no means mandatory, the typical superhero story structure often goes like this:

**Hook:** often an action scene that pulls the Heroes into the story.

**Exposition:** the call to adventure, this is an investigation or social scene in which the Heroes learn something about the story and set out to accomplish their goals.

**Action:** an action scene more intense than the first that progresses the story.

**Rising Exposition:** the stakes get raises, this is an investigation or social scene that not only moves the story forward but also ramps up the pace, stakes, or tension.

**Rising Action:** an even more intense action scene, often one in which the Heroes suffer some kind of defeat or setback or learn something that makes their situation even more dire.

**Preparation:** an investigation or social scene in which the Heroes learn what they need to accomplish their goals and everyone prepares for the final confrontation. If a Hero is being spotlighted in the story, this is often when that character must face a hard choice or personal sacrifice.

**Climax:** usually the most intense action scene of the entire story, this is when the Heroes must confront the Villains and save the city or otherwise accomplish their goals.

**Finale:** this brief social scene concludes the story and highlights any loose ends.

Another way to think about your stories is in terms of pinch points and playgrounds. **Pinch points** are the scenes that must happen in the story, while **playgrounds** are the scenes that happen between pinch points. The hook, for example, is a pinch point that gets the story rolling. After that, the players are in the playground, and can take the story in any number of directions, depending on what they do. However, whatever they do, they will eventually find their way to the next pinch point, which then opens another playground of possibilities. And so forth, until you reach the climax. In most superhero games, pinch points tend to be action scenes. In stories of a more investigative bent, pinch points tend to be the scenes in which the Heroes stumble across the next Big Clue to whatever mystery they're trying to solve.



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However you structure your story, most games should increase in pace and tension as the Heroes move through them. While no superhero story should start off slow, all stories should gain steam over time and be cooking with gas by the time you reach the climax. Similarly, the challenges faced by the Heroes (physical, mental, and social) should become more daunting as the story progresses.

Scenes should also be of varying lengths and types. Some will be action oriented, often involving combat and a lot of dice rolling. Others will be intellectually oriented, with players making plans, solving puzzles, or unraveling mysteries. And others will be socially oriented, filled with character interaction and intense roleplaying. Different players enjoy different things, but no one wants to endure the relentless assault of identical scenes presented one after another like some Bataan Death March of bad gaming. Vary your scenes and try to include a little something for everyone.

## TRAPPINGS

You're just about done. The last thing you need to do is add a few trappings, little details that help bring the game world to life for your players. The two most important trappings are the Extras with whom the Heroes interact and the sets where your important scenes take place.

### SAMPLE DISTINCTIONS

| |
|---|
| **Adornment:** The character always wears an unusual piece of jewelry or fashion accessory. |
| **Age:** The character is unusually young or unusually old for the role they play in the story. |
| **Aroma:** For better or worse, there is something distinctive about how the character smells. |
| **Attire:** The character always wears clothing of a certain type, brand, or color. |
| **Bald:** The character is partially or totally bald, maybe even sporting a comb over. |
| **Blemishes:** The character has warts, moles, patches of discolored skin, or acne. |
| **Disfigurement:** The character has been permanently disfigured or scarred in some way. |
| **Expressive:** The character wears their emotions on their sleeve and isn't ashamed of it. |
| **Facial Hair:** The character sports a beard, moustache, goatee, or sideburns. |
| **Family Man/Woman:** The character is devoted to their family and talks about them constantly. |
| **Fan:** The character is a rabid fan of something and just can't shut up about it. |
| **Fashion:** The character is either extremely fashion-forward or an absolute fashion nightmare. |
| **Fastidious:** The character is always immaculately clean, neat, and well-groomed. |
| **Hair:** The character sports a slick, weird, distinct, or downright absurd looking hairstyle or color. |
| **Health Nightmare:** The character eats like they're looking forward to the next heart attack. |
| **Health Nut:** The character is in great shape and is always careful about what they eat and drink. |
| **Hobby:** The character has an unusual hobby that frequently makes its way into conversations. |
| **Hot:** The character is ridiculously attractive or sexy, enough that it's distracting. |
| **Humor:** The character has a very strange or dark sense of humor that most people don't get. |
| **Hyper:** The character is always running around and can't sit still for more than a few moments. |
| **Jerk:** The character is totally devoid of social skills and comes off as an insensitive boor. |
| **Languorous:** The character moves and speaks very slowly, perhaps maddeningly so. |
| **Nervous Habit:** The character has a nervous habit like biting their nails or drumming their fingers. |
| **Nice:** The character is genuinely and unusually nice, almost eerily so. |
| **Personal Troubles:** Everyone knows the character's personal life is always in shambles. |
| **Personality:** For better or worse, the character has a very distinct personality or outlook. |
| **Pet:** The character is totally devoted to their pet or pets and talks about them constantly. |
| **Prejudice:** The character dislikes members of a certain race, religion, gender, or other group. |
| **Religious:** The character is deeply religious; they may or may not be a fanatic (see Zealot). |
| **Reserved:** The character is always calm and keeps their emotions in check. |
| **Restricted Diet:** Everyone knows the character abides by a strict set of dietary restrictions. |
| **Smoker:** The character is always smoking a cigarette, cigar, or pipe. |
| **Speech:** The character's speech is distinctive: they might have a lisp, a stutter, or an accent. |
| **Timing:** No matter the situation, the character is either always late or always early. |
| **Tattoos:** The character sports one or more visible tattoos. |
| **Unkempt:** The character always looks messy and wrinkled, like they've slept in their clothes. |
| **Voice:** The character's voice is distinctive: especially deep, high, loud, soft, or irritating. |
| **Whack-Job:** The character is downright loco: exactly how is up to you. |
| **Zealot:** The character is totally, slavishly, and very vocally devoted to some cause. |



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## EXTRAS

Although Villains and Foes are important characters in most stories, the Heroes are probably going to interact more with your Extras than with any other characters. That being the case, you should give your Extras as much detail as you need to bring them to life while playing the game. Important Extras should have the same finishing touches as Heroes or Villains (which one you use depends on the Extra) even if you don't bother creating them as complete characters. You need to know who your Extras are to play them, but you don't necessarily need to know everything they can do.

As GM, you are literally playing everyone else on the planet (in the galaxy, the universe, etc.) so you might not be ready with a fully fleshed-out description when the players decide to strike up a conversation with some random NPC. If you find yourself in a pinch when describing an Extra, give them one or more distinctions to help create an interesting or memorable character on the fly.

## SETS

Sets are locations the Heroes will visit in the story. Although sets are often mapped out, that isn't necessary. Some sets, such as those where a fight or an action scene is likely to occur, probably require at least some amount of detail, in which case preparing a map ahead of time is a good idea, but most require nothing more than a few choice descriptors. As with everything else, do only as much prep work as you need to feel comfortable. Whenever possible, choose dramatic, exotic, or unusual locations for your sets. Watch action movies and notice where their action scenes take place. Keep your eyes open for interesting places you can use as the basis for your sets. If you're having trouble coming up with interesting sets, the following tables include generic locations and specific real-world locales.

The best sets become part of the action, enhance the mood, and help make the game more compelling. When selecting your sets, think about how they can enhance the scenes in which they appear. For action scenes, try finding ways to bring your sets into the action. For investigation scenes, contemplate how you can make your sets part of the mystery, riddle, or puzzle. For social scenes, think about how your sets can ramp up the tension or the drama. Consider the following suggestions for making static sets come to life.

**Civilians:** Crowds and traffic can make it difficult to get anywhere in a hurry and almost impossible to have a super-powered brawl without putting people in serious jeopardy.

**Dangers:** Sets can include hazards such as barbed wire, downed power lines, explosive gas, hidden landmines, pools of lava, sheer drops, weak floors, traps, and tripwires.

**Derelict:** A long-abandoned set that has fallen into a state of disrepair is both creepy and potentially dangerous. It can also do wonders to create a moody environment.

**Elevations:** Always remember things like balconies, catwalks, ladders, overpasses, pits, ramps, and stairways. A set with varied elevations can make a rather boring fight much more interesting.

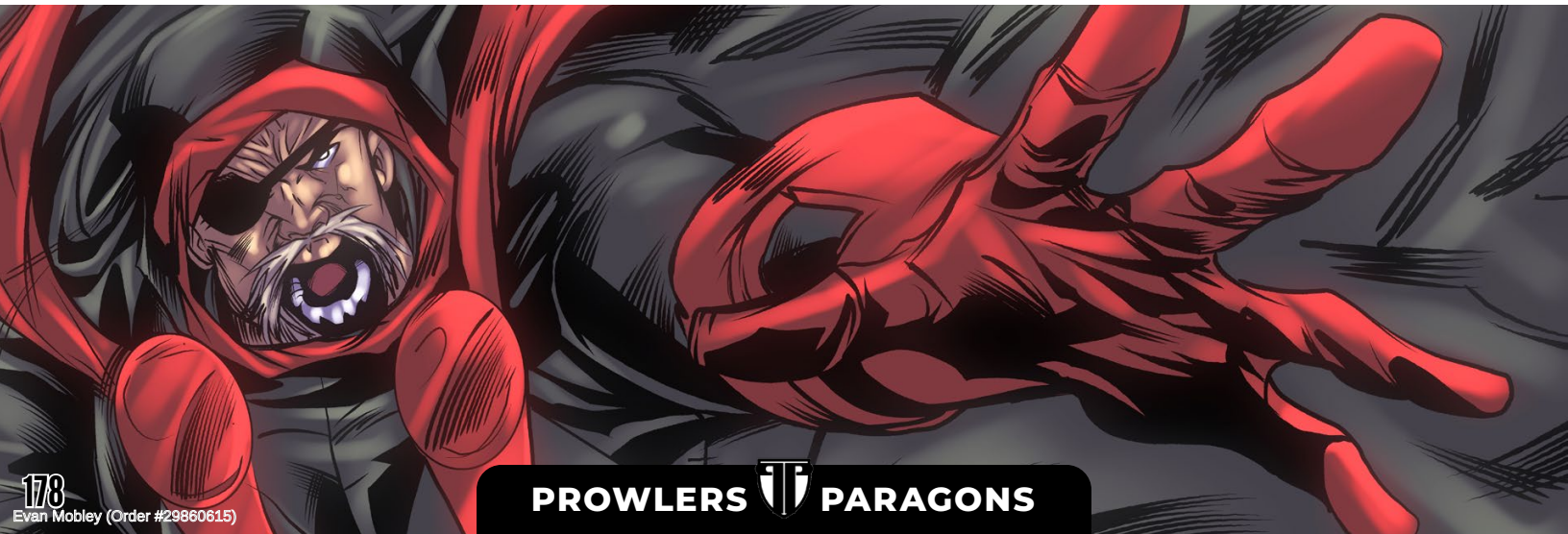
**Moving Parts:** Factories, assembly lines, and other industrial sets should contain moving parts, busily—and often dangerously—going about their business while the Heroes do their thing.

**Noise:** Background noise can add realism, underscore the mood, and act as another variable. A loud set can hamper communication and perception; a quiet one can create an eerie or unsettling mood.

**Obstacles:** The Heroes may need to cross treacherous bridges, scale or tunnel under thick walls, swing across chasms, swim through water-filled passages, or squeeze through narrow spaces.

**Visibility:** Lighting, darkness, fog, smoke, strobe lights, and anything else that impacts visibility can affect both the atmosphere and the tactical aspects of a set.

**Weather:** Weather can affect both mood and game mechanics. Wind, rain, snow, ice, and fog all convey a certain mood, and can make things more difficult for the Heroes in one way or another.





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## GENERIC SETS

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Airplanes | Hotels | Parking Lots |
| Airport Terminals | Hydroelectric Dams | Police Stations |
| Alleys | Inside the Hollow Earth | Pyramids |
| Amusement Parks | Jungles | Research Labs |
| Ancient Ruins | Junkyards | Restaurants |
| Archeological Sites | Lost Primeval Worlds | Rooftops |
| Arenas | Libraries | Runways |
| Asteroids | Malls | Secret Headquarters |
| Atlantis | Mansions | Sewers |
| Bars | Mausoleums | Skyscrapers |
| Beach Resorts | Military Compounds | Spaceports |
| Bridges | Mines | Spaceships |
| Bullet Trains | Monasteries | Stadiums |
| Buses | The Moon | Submarines |
| Bus Terminals | Movie Theaters | Subway Cars |
| Casinos | Museums | Subway Stations |
| Castles | National Monuments | Subway Tunnels |
| Caves | National Parks | Swamps |
| Cemeteries | Nightclubs | Temples |
| Churches | Oases | Tenements |
| City Streets | Ocean Liners | Tourist Attractions |
| Construction Sites | Oil Refineries | Trains |
| Craters | Oil Rigs | Train Terminals |
| Dense Forests | On Moving Vehicles | Train Yards |
| Deserts | Open Air Markets | Tunnels |
| Docks | Opera Houses | Under Overpasses |
| Dungeons | Orbital Bases | Underwater |
| Elevated Trains | Other Dimensions | Universities |
| Elevator Shafts | Other Planets | Utility Plants |
| Factories | Outdoor Cafes | Volcanoes |
| Fairgrounds | Outdoor Festivals | Warehouses |
| Government Buildings | Palaces | Waterfalls |
| Hospitals | Parking Garages | Waterfront Markets |

## SPECIFIC SETS

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| The Acropolis | The Grand Canyon | The Panama Canal |
| Angkor Wat | The Great Sphinx | The Pentagon |
| The Basilica of Saint Peter | The Great Wall of China | The Pyramids of Giza |
| The Brandenburg Gate | The Hollywood Sign | The Rock and Roll Hall of Fame |
| The Burj Khalifa | The Hoover Dam | Sears (Willis) Tower |
| Chichēn Itzā | The Kremlin | The Smithsonian |
| The Clock Tower of London | The Leaning Tower of Pisa | The South Pole |
| The CN Tower | The Lincoln Memorial | The Space Needle |
| The Colosseum | The London Underground | The Statue of Liberty |
| Easter Island | The Louvre | Stonehenge |
| The Eiffel Tower | Machu Picchu | The Sydney Opera House |
| The Empire State Building | Mount Rushmore | The Taj Mahal |
| The Forbidden City | The Museum of Natural History | The Washington Monument |
| The Gateway Arch | The North Pole | The White House |
| Golden Gate Bridge | The Palace of Versailles | Windsor Castle |



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# CREATING SERIES

As mentioned earlier, a **series** is a group of related stories that get played out in order. In other games, this would be called a campaign. There's no right way or wrong way to create a series. As with the previous section, this isn't intended to teach you the one and only way to go about doing that. Instead, think of this section as a checklist of things to consider when creating a new series.

## SETTING

The setting refers to the world (physical and thematic) in which the game takes place. Some settings require more homework than others. A game set in our modern-day world doesn't require a lot of prep. The same goes for a game set in any world you're already familiar with, such as any of the major comic book universes. However, if you're going to run a game set in an unfamiliar world, you'll need to spend a little time creating it. Because this is an action-oriented roleplaying game, we suggest not going overboard. Create enough of the world to let your players get their bearings and make up the rest as you go, often by taking input from the players themselves. Whatever you decide, it's important that you pick a setting everyone finds interesting. If you're the only one of your friends who grooves on a particular setting, don't set your game there. Some common superheroic settings are listed below.

### ALTERNATE HISTORY

The series takes place in a world like ours might have been had history been different, probably the most common example being if the Axis powers had won World War II.

### CONTEMPORARY

The easiest and most common setting for traditional comic book superheroes, the series takes place in our modern-day world, or in one very similar to the one we know.

### CYBERPUNK

The series is set in a dystopian near-future ruled by corporations and the wealthy elite and characterized by the ubiquity of cybernetics and the dehumanization they bring.

### CYBERPUNK FANTASY

Take a cyberpunk setting and add fantasy races, magic, and monsters to taste.

### DIESELPUNK

The series takes place in an often dystopian pulp era set between the World Wars and characterized by retro-futuristic diesel-powered technology and a pervasive art deco style.

### EASTERN FANTASY

The series is set in a fantasy world based on Arabian, Chinese, Indian, Japanese, Persian, or other Eastern cultures and mythologies, or an amalgam of them.

### HIGH FANTASY

The series is set in a medieval fantasy world based on Western mythology.

### HISTORIC

The series is set in our world at some point in history. Popular historic settings for comic book superheroes include the Old West, the Age of Sail, the Victorian Era, and World War II.

### POST-APOCALYPTIC

The series is set on our world or another after a devastating catastrophe, sometimes natural, but more often than not man-made (oh, the humanity).

### PULP

The series takes place in that two-fisted time between the 1920s and the 1930s. It's kind of like Dieselpunk, but lighter in tone and without all the retro-fetishism.

### RETRO-FUTURE

The series is set in the somewhat whimsical future envisioned in much early science fiction. Think fishbowl helmets and ray guns with fins.

### SCI-FI

The series, which often takes place in our distant future, it set in a science fiction setting where things like aliens, faster-than-light travel, and laser weapons are commonplace.

### STEAMPUNK

The series is set in a fantastical Victorian Era (often one much less dystopian than the actual historical period) characterized by fantasy races, magic, and fantastical steam-powered technology.

### SWORD-AND-PLANET

The series is set on a primitive and barbaric world, often Mars or Venus, and characterized by quaint retro sci-fi technology envisioned by early twentieth-century authors.

### SWORD-AND-SORCERY

The series is set in a typically grim and barbaric fantasy world.

### URBAN FANTASY

The series takes place in our modern world, or one very much like it, but one in which magic, mythical creatures, and monsters are real.

### WORLD-HOPPING

The series has no single setting because, for whatever reason, the Heroes will travel to different worlds and/or times over the course of the series (oh boy).

## PREMISE

The premise describes what the Heroes are doing in the series. Some of the more common premises for series are described below, but these are only ideas. Some of the premises below are closely related to certain heroic motivations set forth in



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Chapter 2. This should not affect the motivations players select for their Heroes. A Hero's motivation is about them; it does not need to tie-in to the overall premise of a series. Like many works of fiction, comic books are full of characters with disparate motivations who nevertheless band together for a singular purpose.

### ADVENTURE
The Heroes are adventurers, traveling wherever their fortunes may lead them. Their heroics come from helping those they encounter on their journeys.

### CONSPIRACY
This series appears to be something else at the start, but over time, the Heroes slowly become aware that something terrible is happening and nothing is as it seems. These series can evolve into anything, but they usually move in the direction of comedy, horror, or intrigue.

### ESPIONAGE
The Heroes are secret agents working for the government or some noble independent organization. These series often pit the Heroes against agents of an evil spy organization.

### FREELANCERS
The Heroes are private detectives, heroes-for-hire, or soldiers of fortune, and the series follows their adventures as they help those in need of their unique abilities.

### FUGITIVES
This series involves Heroes on the wrong side of the law, doing what they can to fight the power, or maybe just to survive. The Heroes are often criminals by virtue of their special gifts, because they belong to a hated or oppressed group, because they steal from the rich and give to the poor, etc.

### GOTHIC UNDERWORLD
The Heroes are monsters of myth and legend, beings like vampires, werewolves, ghosts, goblins, fairies, and the like, making their way among a (mostly) clueless human populace.

### LAW ENFORCEMENT
The Heroes are members of a law enforcement agency, and the series involves the usual elements like investigating crimes, chasing criminals, and going undercover.

### MILITARY
The Heroes are members of a military or paramilitary organization. Some of these series pit the Heroes against an evil paramilitary organization or an alien or extradimensional invasion. Others have the Heroes working for a rebellion against an evil empire. And others involve an actual historical war.

### NOBLES
The Heroes are members of a royal line or a unique lineage that grants them their abilities, and the series concerns them carrying out the obligations that are their birthright.

### ORDINARY FOLKS
The Heroes were ordinary people who recently developed or discovered their powers and are now trying to understand what this means for themselves and their families.

### SUPERHEROES
The Heroes are individuals who for various reasons have banded together — or will band together at the start of the series — to protect the innocent and combat the forces of evil.

## MOOD
Mood describes the general tone and feel of your series. Is it silly and lighthearted, dark and serious, or somewhere in between? Just because a series has a mood doesn't mean that every scene of every story should share that mood. That should never be the case. You need contrast to make things stand out. Even the darkest series should have moments of happiness or levity, and even the lightest should have its serious or sad moments. As with the setting, you should discuss the game's mood with your players ahead of time. If everyone wants lots of angst, they probably won't be satisfied with a four-color heroic slugfest played mostly for laughs. To keep things simple, mood is broken down into five categories: bleak, dark, standard, light, and comedic. Each is described below.

### BLEAK
The series is extremely cynical, grim, and almost hopeless. The optional Gritty Combat Rules are pretty much required, as death and tragedy will probably be all-too common.

### DARK
The series is somber, or at least serious, and will probably deal with issues and involve conflicts deeper and more complex than simple good guys versus bad guys. At least some of the optional Gritty Combat Rules may be appropriate to underscore the fact that this isn't all fun and games.

### STANDARD
The series is neither especially dark nor light, but individual stories may vary. Overall, it will probably be on par with most major comic book titles and all but the darkest comic book movies.

### LIGHT
The series is lighthearted, about on par with the average superhero cartoon. Characters never get seriously hurt, much less killed, and heavy topics or moral quandaries are generally avoided or given only the slightest nod. There may be ups and downs, but everything will turn out alright in the end.

### COMEDIC
The series is not at all serious and may well be played purely for laughs. Although comedic one-shots can be fun, it can be difficult to maintain this mood over a series of any real length.


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# HEROES

No, this isn't where you create the Heroes. You might create Heroes for a one-shot, or maybe for a game you plan to run at a convention, but not for an ongoing series. It's always better to let players create their own Heroes so they'll be invested in them right from the start. Instead, what you need to do as GM is help set the ground rules regarding the kinds of Heroes that will be suitable for the game.

## POWER LEVEL

The first thing you need to do is select a power level. Will the Heroes be street-level prowlers, paragons with godlike abilities, or somewhere in between? This depends on what the Heroes will be doing and what kind of adversaries they'll be facing. As discussed in Chapter 2, this also determines the game's Trait Cap and the number of Hero Points the players have to create their characters. It's important to understand that these numbers are somewhat arbitrary. If you want to give your players 100 or 150 Hero Points instead of the usual 125 Hero Points in a Standard game with a 12d Trait Cap, feel free to do so. Hero points exist to maintain some level of balance among the Heroes, so the exact number is less important than the fact that all Heroes have the same amount.

## TRAIT CAP

Whatever your game's power level or starting Hero Points may be, keep an eye on abilities that work in tandem or grant flat bonuses. Even when a Hero's ranks fall within the game's Trait Cap, Powers like Growth and Shrinking can push a Hero's effective rank over the edge. As the GM, feel free to restrict any combination of Abilities, Talents, and Powers that effectively exceeds the game's Trait Cap.

On the other hand, the Trait Cap isn't set in stone. It matters when dealing with attacks, defenses, and Traits that affect other characters. However, certain Powers aren't particularly game-breaking at any rank. For example, 12d Teleportation lets you travel 100 miles. If a player in a game with a 12d Trait Cap wants to be able to teleport anywhere in the world, there's no real reason to say no, even though that requires a Teleportation rank of 18d. Sure, the Hero can travel farther in a single jump. But so what? On the other end of the spectrum, a Hero with 15d Armor, Might, or (heaven forbid) Mind Control in a game with a 12d Trait Cap will have an unbalancing impact on the game and should not be permitted.

## SUITABILITY

The other thing to consider is the kind of Heroes that fit your series. Heroes have to fit not only the setting but also the mood of your game. For example, an alien explorer doesn't fit the setting of an American Old West game, and a Mystery Man



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styled pulp detective doesn't fit the setting of a star-spanning game about Heroes that protect the galaxy. Similarly, a deeply troubled and emotionally scarred addict doesn't fit the mood of a light-hearted game based on Saturday morning cartoons, and a bubbly Anime-inspired magic schoolgirl doesn't fit the mood of a gritty game about low-powered supers operating in occupied France during the Second World War. To avoid conflicts like these, make sure your players understand the mood and setting of the game you intend to run.

### METAPLOT

The last thing to consider is whether your game will have a metaplot, an overarching storyline that unfolds over the course of the series. If so, you should give some thought to how much of an impact you want that metaplot to have in the game. As with everything else, there are tradeoffs.

Some series are metaplot heavy, with a tight plotline that unfolds over the course of the campaign. Most stories involve the metaplot in some way, directly or indirectly advancing it towards its eventual climax and resolution. The series may include occasional interludes that aren't related to the metaplot, but these will be rare. This kind of series allows you and your players to tell an epic story, but it can be tedious if the series goes on too long. Worse, if handled improperly, these series can make players feel like they're being told a story rather than helping to create one.

Other series are metaplot light, with a loose plotline that unfolds over the course of the campaign but doesn't intrude itself into every story. Some stories will involve the metaplot and others won't. This kind of series also lets you and your players tell an epic story, but it doesn't bash you over the head with it. It gives players more freedom to do whatever they want with their Heroes because not every story is going to involve some grand overarching plotline. The downside, however, is that it takes much longer to tell a truly epic story in this kind of game.

And last, some series have no metaplot at all. In series like these, the game moves from one story to the next and ends when everyone tires of it. The stories in this kind of series are self-contained, having little connection to those that come before it or those that follow. The only common threads in these stories are the Heroes themselves and maybe some recurring NPCs. The advantage of this kind of series is that the Heroes are free to do anything they want without fear of derailing the game. The disadvantage is that series like these can feel aimless. Without the progression of a larger story, these series can start to feel like a mindless exercise in beating up one Villain after another.

## NARRATIVE TECHNIQUES

Writers use a variety of narrative techniques to make their stories more interesting. Although this is a game and not a story, some of these techniques translate well into roleplaying. While you shouldn't overuse them, these techniques can make your games more entertaining and memorable.

### CLIFFHANGERS

There's no better way to end an issue than with a cliffhanger. A cliffhanger is a classic trope in which one episode or issue ends with the Heroes in serious trouble or discovering some shocking revelation. Because this happens at the end of the game, the players can't do anything about it until the next time they play. Ideally, this should create excitement and anticipation for the next game, and one issue's cliffhanger can get the next issue off to a great start.

### CONTRAST

Contrast intensifies the effect of whatever you want to highlight, especially when it comes to a scene's mood or pace. If you want to make something about a scene really stand out or feel more powerful, do the exact opposite in the previous scene. For example, if you have a scene in which the Heroes are going to receive some depressing news, make sure they're happy and having fun right before that happens. Similarly, if the Heroes are going to be pulled into a frantic chase in one scene, make sure the scene before that is a bit more low-key. The players will feel the difference.

### CUT SCENES

A cut scene is a brief scene that isn't about the Heroes. It tells the players something about the story the Heroes don't know and can't act on. Just like when you're reading a comic book in which you know something the Heroes don't, this can create tension and make the story more interesting.

For example, a cut scene can let the players know that their Heroes have only a limited amount of time to accomplish some objective. Or it can show the main Villain doing something that tells the players how powerful, how evil, or even — and this one will really throw your players for a loop — how sympathetic a character the Villain really is. You might even try to get all artsy and use cut scenes to juxtapose something happening elsewhere in the game world with what the Heroes are doing. Juxtaposition can be tricky and has a very high potential cheese factor, though, so be careful with it.

Whatever the case, most cut scenes should be very brief. Give the players a quick description of what happens in the cut scene and then get right back to the Heroes. No one wants to watch you put on a one-man or one-woman show, not even your mother. If you really want to engage your players in a cut scene, have them play the scene out (see Playing Other Characters below).

The one downside of a cut scene is that it breaks immersion. It takes the players out of their Heroes' heads and turns them into an audience. It shows the players things their Heroes haven't seen or gives them information their Heroes don't know. For these reasons, some GMs don't use cut scenes, preferring instead to let the players experience the game world only through their Heroes. There's no right or wrong here; it's a matter of personal preference.



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## FORESHADOWING

Foreshadowing is a tricky technique that's easy to use but hard to use well. It involves dropping hints about something that will happen later in the game but making those hints too subtle for the players to figure out what's being foreshadowed. The players aren't supposed to notice these hints, much less figure out what they mean. The hints should just sit there, in the background, ignored by everyone until whatever has been foreshadowed occurs. When it does, the players should look back and see that those hints were staring them in the face all along. If it's done right, foreshadowing can be tremendously powerful and make for a truly memorable game.

## INTERLUDES

An interlude is a scene that involves one or more of the Heroes but isn't related to the plot of the story. Interludes provide a break in the action and afford the players an opportunity to roleplay their Heroes in their daily lives, giving them a bit more depth. Interludes can range from brief moments of comic relief to major subplots that get played out over multiple stories and forever alter a Hero's life.

Unlike the other techniques in this section, players create interludes. Players are encouraged to design interludes for their Heroes and present them to the GM. If they wish, two or more players can join forces and create an interlude that involves multiple Heroes. GMs should run these interludes by fitting them into the game whenever they can and adding their own ideas into the mix. If players don't like how their interlude is going, they can put it on hold and discuss it with the GM at the end of the issue. The two can then either modify the interlude or cancel it at the player's discretion (players have complete authority over their interludes). As a reward for adding to the narrative, players earn 1 Resolve whenever their interludes get played out during an issue. Each Hero is allowed only one interlude (or one joint interlude) per story, and GMs should usually run no more than one or two interludes per issue. There are many different types of interludes, but some of the more common ones are listed below.

### CIVIC DUTY

The Hero performs a minor civic or heroic activity that doesn't involve thwarting some grand plot, something like foiling a purse snatching, getting a cat out of a tree, making a charity appearance, or speaking to a group of kids. We get to see the character be heroic in an everyday setting.

### COMIC RELIEF

Something funny or embarrassing happens to the Hero. This is a great way to add some depth to serious Heroes and grim loner types. You may be the best there is at what you do, and it may not be very pretty, but if you have to do it in a pink bunny suit, we're still going to laugh at you.

### FLASHBACK

This interlude can involve just about anything, but it usually concerns a situation that happened in the past and somehow relates to the current story. When the GM runs a flashback, it's usually to provide players with clues or details for the larger story. When a flashback is played as an interlude, however, its main purpose is to tell us something about the Heroes.

### FRIEND IN NEED

One of the Hero's civilian friends needs mundane help of the real-life variety. Maybe the friend is addicted to alcohol or drugs, is facing a divorce, got kicked out of school, or was fired from their job. This kind of interlude helps us get to know the person behind the mask. This is a great interlude to happen between Heroes, especially when one is struggling with a personal sacrifice of the kind discussed earlier.

### PERSONAL TRIUMPH

Something wonderful occurs in the Hero's personal life. Maybe the Hero gets married, has a child, gets accepted into the college of their dreams, wins that big promotion, or finally finishes writing that stupid roleplaying game they've been working on for so long. Just like Friend in Need, this interlude helps turn the Hero into something more than a two-dimensional guy or gal in a mask.

### PERSONAL TROUBLE

The Hero faces a tragedy like the death or severe illness of a loved one. Or maybe the Hero has to deal with a serious life issue such as marital troubles, getting fired, being kicked out of school, or deciding to write a second edition of that stupid roleplaying game. This kind of interlude shows us how the Hero deals with problems that can't be fixed with superpowers.

### ROMANCE

The Hero meets someone who makes them feel all warm and fuzzy inside. The subject of the crush may or may not reciprocate. If they do, sure, they're probably a Villain. But maybe not, and unless and until that revelation occurs, this interlude shows us the softer side of even the darkest Hero.

## PLAYING OTHER CHARACTERS

While it may sound strange, occasionally having the players run characters other than their Heroes can be fun. Depending on the game, the players might run these other characters for one scene, several scenes, or even an entire issue. You shouldn't do this too often, but it can be a wonderful change of pace. As with cut scenes, not all GMs like this technique because it also breaks immersion. But if you want to try it, consider the following ways of using this technique in your games.

### ALTERED STATES

The players run different versions of their Heroes living in an alternate time, world, or dimension. Often, the idea behind an altered states story is that the players are actually running their Heroes, who will end up having to fix whatever went wrong with the world so that it returns to normal.



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### FLASHBACK
The Heroes relive something that happened in the past. This sometimes occurs in cut scenes spread over the course of a story occurring in the present. The connection between the flashback and the present can be obvious from the start, or it might be revealed as the story progresses.

### OTHER LIVES
Often used for an entire story, the players run other characters in the past or the future and eventually learn that those characters are their Heroes in their past or future lives. Yes, it's corny, but this is a game about comic book superheroes, and this technique can make for some cheesy fun.

### VICTIMS
The players begin a new story running characters other than their Heroes. These characters are eventually kidnapped, killed, or whatever. Once this happens, the players switch to their regular Heroes, who get tasked with finding out what happened to the original characters.

### VILLAINS
Some of the most interesting stories in comic books focus on the Villains rather than the Heroes. The same applies to roleplaying, especially when you ask players to run Villains they really hate, people who've made their lives miserable (the longer the better). To be effective, this technique requires mature players who are willing to take this seriously and play these characters well.

## SPOTLIGHTING
Whenever you have a comic about a group of superheroes, not every story can be about every character. Some stories are about the group. Others spotlight a particular character, focusing primarily on them over the course of that story. Your games can work the same way.

When using this technique, some stories will involve all the Heroes equally, while others will revolve around specific Heroes. These spotlighting stories might involve the Hero's nemesis, their family or friends, something from their past, or their long-term goals. This is much easier to do when your players give you information to work with, which is why Heroes have connections, details, and an origin. You should take turns spotlighting Heroes, focusing on one per story. Over time, every Hero will get to be in the spotlight, and every Hero's goals and backstories will become an integral part of your series.

As mentioned above, don't feel obligated to spotlight a Hero in every story. You can if you wish, but you can also mix stories that spotlight one Hero with those that involve all the Heroes equally. In fact, this latter approach makes the spotlighting stories that much more compelling. Just be sure to give every Hero equal treatment when using this technique.

# GAMEMASTER TIPS
A great GM can make any story interesting and fun. Unfortunately, the art of being a great GM is just that: an art. It's something you learn over time and never perfect. While you can learn a lot from reading about it or watching other people run games, the best way to hone your skills as a GM is to run a lot of games, make a lot of mistakes, and get a lot of feedback. With that in mind, the following tips and suggestions should be thought of as guidelines to help you move through the cycle of falling down and getting back up again on your road to being a great GM.

## COMIC BOOK HEROES
Always remember that the Heroes are the main characters of the series. No other characters should be anywhere near as important to the game. The Heroes must be the ones to save the world, even if they aren't the ones who run it. They must be the ones to fire the shot that destroys the giant space station, even if they aren't the ones who planned the attack. And they must be the ones to fend off the evil cosmic entity, even if they aren't nearly as powerful as the good cosmic entity who — for whatever reason — can only advise them and then sit back on their cosmic couch with some low-fat cosmic popcorn to watch what happens. The Heroes don't have to be the most powerful or influential people in the game world. They usually aren't. What they are, however, is the focus of the series. If the players ever tell you they feel overshadowed by one of your NPCs, listen to them. And remove that NPC from the game.

## FAIRNESS
As GM, you are the referee of the game. You oversee the application of the rules and determine when they need to be bent, broken, or ignored. This means you must be fair and consistent. While you might occasionally bend the rules, this should be to further the story, make the game more exciting, or give a new player a break (which we encourage). However, you must be a neutral arbiter, favoring neither the Heroes nor their adversaries. If you always favor the Heroes, the players won't feel challenged and will eventually get bored. If you always favor the Villains, the players won't feel empowered and will eventually get disheartened. Neither result is good.

## IMPROVISING
At some point, your players will go completely off the rails. They'll breeze through what should have been a whole night's worth of story in under an hour, or they'll spend an entire night following a red herring. They'll be stumped by a simple puzzle, or they'll solve a convoluted mystery the moment they find the first clue. They'll struggle against a sad little group of Minions, then plow through your toughest Villains without working up a sweat. This is when roleplaying becomes something more than acting or war gaming; this is when it really becomes an exercise in cooperative, improvisational storytelling.


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One of the most entertaining things about roleplaying is that you never know what to expect, whether as a player or a GM. Any good story that doesn't involve railroading the Heroes from one scene to the next will give your players countless opportunities to catch you off guard. No matter how well prepared you think you are, your players will do things you didn't expect. When that occurs, you're going to have to wing it and improvise what happens next. The more you GM, the more you'll come to relish these moments as the most exciting part of running a game. But whether you fear or love them, these moments will happen, so be prepared, be flexible, and be ready to improvise.

## KEEP IT MOVING

This is an action-adventure roleplaying game about super-powered Heroes and Villains. It's neither a tactical war game nor a detailed simulation of anything in the real world. The goal is to have fun, not to win the game or determine how things might play out in real life, so speed is more important than precision. Know the rules and understand how they work. Know the story you're going to run. And be ready to make judgment calls on the fly. That's your job as GM. Your goal is to facilitate the game, not delay it, so spend as little time as possible checking your notes or flipping through the rules at the table. Never let the game come to a grinding halt while you look something up. If you can find what you need quickly, great. But if not, then just make a judgment call and move on. Don't let yourself be rushed, but keep the game moving. If you discover that you've made a mistake, that's fine too. Acknowledge it, remember it for the future, and you're good.

## METAGAMING

Metagaming means using information you know but your character doesn't when playing the game. The term often applies to players, but GMs can also be accused of metagaming when running NPCs. Although this opinion isn't universal, metagaming is typically considered bad form. It's viewed as cheating because you're basing a character's actions or decisions on information they have no way of knowing. To some extent, this destroys the verisimilitude of the game. When a character's actions are determined by what the GM or the player knows rather than by what the character knows, it shatters the illusion of playing an imaginary character in an imaginary world.

For example, if one of your players accidentally sees your notes and learns where to find a Villain's secret lair, that player's Hero can't act on that information. Similarly, even though you as the GM know all there is to know about the Heroes, it would be unfair for your NPCs to act on that information. In both cases, metagaming is basically cheating, taking advantage of things a character shouldn't know.

Because this is a game, however, there are times when metagaming is not only acceptable, but *helpful*. For example, when the Heroes meet for the first time, everyone should understand they're going to need to come together. Sure, they may not all like or trust each other right from the get-go. But the Heroes are going to have to band together eventually, and everyone must be willing to nudge their Heroes in that direction. Other examples of good metagaming by players include taking obvious plot hooks and trying to avoid splitting the team (which is a good way to get things done in real life, but a bad idea in a roleplaying game for several reasons, the greatest of which is that a GM can only pay attention to one group at a time, leaving everyone else sitting around doing nothing in the meanwhile). In cases like this, metagaming isn't cheating and doesn't have a negative impact on the game. On the contrary, it serves to help the game along and is therefore encouraged.

## PROPS

Although they're entirely optional, physical props can add a wonderful touch to almost any game. Because most of what happens in the game takes place in the imagination, there's something very powerful about what amounts to pulling a tangible object out of the game world and handing it to the players. Story elements such as written orders, newspaper clippings, photographs, letters, scraps of paper, half-burned journal entries, and encoded messages are all more interesting when players can actually hold them in their hands, read them for themselves, or hear them. And players always appreciate the effort put into buying or making even the cheesiest prop. If you have the time and inclination, you should always consider how you might bring a prop or two into your games.

## RAILROADING

Railroading is when a GM sets the game up in such a way that the players must follow a specific course of action. This usually involves actions that move the plot in a specific direction, but it can also take the form of obstacles or puzzles that can only be overcome in one specific way (determined by the GM ahead of time). As you probably suspect, railroading is generally frowned upon because it robs players of the only thing they are allowed to do in the game: control their Heroes. It turns what should be a game into an interactive story and the GM into a storyteller. This is boring and frustrating for the players, who are there to play, not to see the GM perform.

If you ever feel compelled to railroad your players, stop the game. Literally stop the game and take a break. It means your players caught you off guard and are doing something you didn't expect. Take a moment to regroup and consider what will happen after they do what they want rather than what you expected. Instead of getting upset that they're ruining your story, remind yourself that once you started playing the game, the story became theirs too, and everyone now has an equal say in how it turns out. And remind yourself that this, in fact, is what keeps the game exciting for you as GM.

There's one exception to the "no railroading" rule, at least when it comes to this genre. GMs should feel free to put the Heroes in just about any situation they wish at the beginning of a new story. Stories should start off with a bang, immediately drawing the players into the action. Sometimes, this means GMs



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determine what happened (and what the Heroes were doing) before the first scene opens. Superhero comics grew out of the pulps, a genre of contrived plots and unlikely coincidences, and the apple didn't fall far from the tree. Accordingly, players need to be okay with a little introductory railroading. While a GM should never have the Heroes do anything absurdly stupid or wildly out of character, players should give their GMs some leeway when it comes to getting a new story rolling.

## ROLLING THE DICE

It may sound strange but knowing when you shouldn't roll dice is at least as important as knowing when you should. Obviously, you roll dice whenever you need to determine the result of an action whose outcome is uncertain. Uncertainty, however, isn't the only thing to consider when determining whether to roll dice. The other things to keep in mind are whether the action is relevant to the game, and whether the game will keep moving forward regardless of the outcome.

Don't make players roll to determine the results of trivial or inconsequential actions. Similarly, don't make them roll to obtain information that fleshes out a story and makes everything more interesting but has no bearing on the game. Lousy games are choked with rolls to determine whether Heroes can accomplish every little task, or to see if they know some tidbit of backstory. Don't run a lousy game. Any time you're about to ask a player to make a roll, ask yourself if there's any reason not to just let the player succeed. If there isn't, if the roll's success or failure won't impact the drama or the excitement of the game in any real way, then let the Hero accomplish the trivial task or give them the information and move on.

On the flipside, don't make players roll for any action that must go a certain way to keep the story moving. If the Heroes need to find a clue to reach the next part of the story, let them find it (thank you, Robin Laws). If you paint yourself into a corner from which you can't escape unless a Hero either makes or fails a roll, don't bother asking for a roll to create the illusion of choice. Instead, just take control of the story, narrate what happens in that moment, and give the Hero 1 point of Resolve. Mind you, this kind of thing shouldn't happen. You should try to avoid these situations by creating flexible stories focused on problems rather than solutions (leave the solutions to the Heroes). But nobody's perfect. If it happens to you, don't try to fake your way around it. Just fess up, pay up, and move on.

## SAYING YES

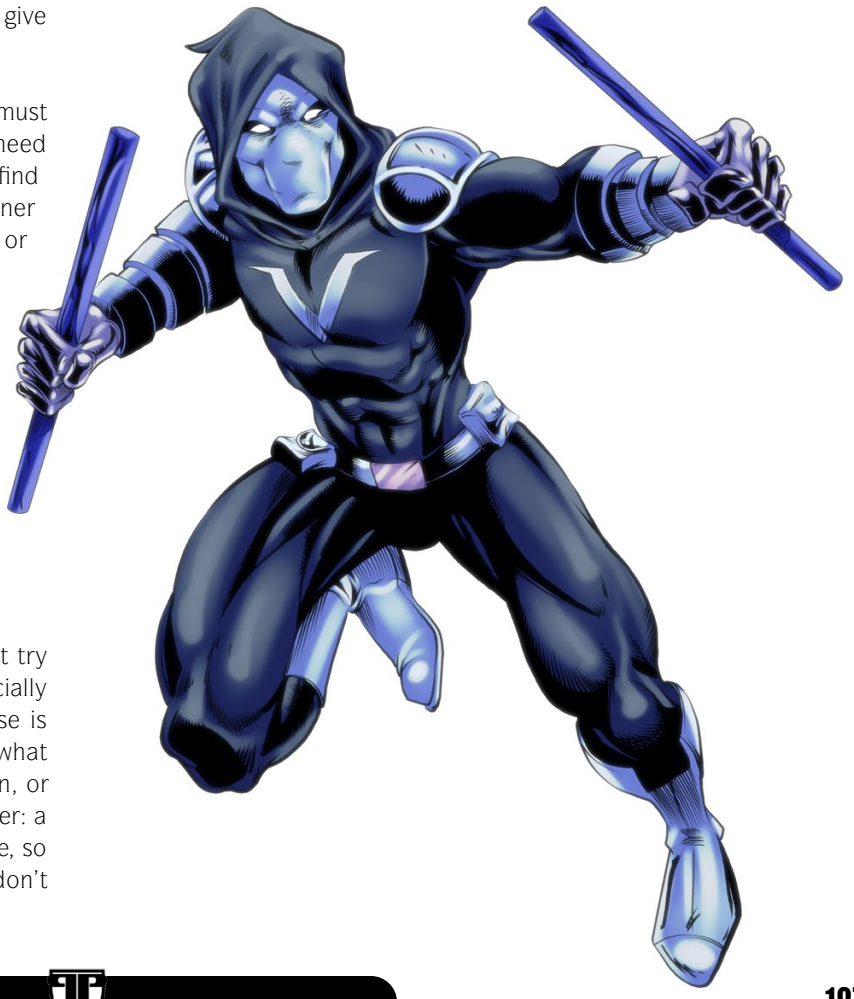
When a player asks if they can do something, or at least try something, your impulse should be to say yes. This is especially true if what they want to attempt is cool. If your impulse is to say no, ask yourself why. Are you saying no because what the player is suggesting is completely out of the question, or because you've been caught off guard? Often, it's the latter: a player hits you with an idea you aren't prepared to handle, so you just say no. While that impulse is understandable, don't give in to it. Instead, take a few minutes to collect your thoughts and see if you can find a way to handle whatever the player just tossed in your lap. Odds are you can. Then let the player try. Remember that the Heroes in this game are superheroes. They're supposed to be able to do ridiculous things, or at least try them. Don't forget that just because you get caught off guard.

# PLAYER TIPS

Everything in this chapter has been about the GM, which makes sense since so much of the game rests on their shoulders. But the GM is just one person, and one person can't be responsible for everyone's fun. The GM is usually going to be outnumbered by the players, so this last section includes a few tips for players, things every GM should reasonably expect.

## DON'T ARGUE

As the referee, your GM is constantly deciding how to apply the rules and making judgement calls about how things work and what is and isn't possible in the game. If you think your GM has made a mistake in their application of the rules or you disagree with one of their calls, tell them and explain why. But once you've shared your opinion and your GM makes a final decision, it's time to move on. If you disagree, discuss this during the next break or after the game ends for the night. Don't bring the game to a grinding halt by debating any point at the table. Even if you're right, it isn't worth the delay.





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## DON'T CHEAT

It's amazing that some people cheat while roleplaying, especially when you consider that there's nothing at stake and no way to win the game. It's natural not to want to see your Hero stumble, be made the fool, or get defeated. But don't cheat. First, it's stupid. Honestly, it just is. Apart from that, the longer you play games like this, the more you come to realize that failure is often more interesting than success. Some of your best gaming stories are going to come from when your Hero really blows it. Roll the dice and let them fall where they may. Trust us: you'll have a lot more fun.

## FOCUS

Pay attention to the game, even when you aren't directly involved in the action. Nothing makes a GM feel less appreciated than seeing players flip through the rules, watch TV, or play around on their laptops or phones. It's utterly disheartening. Being a GM is like being a combination performer, storyteller, and tour guide, and nothing makes a GM feel worse than when their players look bored. Plus, players who tune out often miss important clues and information. If you aren't interested in the game, don't play. If you need a break, take one. But if you're there to play, then give the game your attention.

## GO WITH IT

Creating a memorable roleplaying experience takes cooperation between the GM and the players, but the person who makes the first move is usually the GM, so help yours out when you can. When the GM tosses a plot hook your way, take the bait and get the story going. If you know your GM wants you to do something or go somewhere, try to go with the narrative rather than resist it. Of course, you shouldn't do anything out of character just to appease the GM. But when you see a clear plot hook sitting in front of you, instead of asking yourself whether you would take the bait, maybe assume that you will, and instead ask yourself why. Whenever possible, remember you're playing a game in which everyone has at least some responsibility to go with the flow of the collective narrative.

## HELP OUT

GMs have a hard job. They come up with stories for the Heroes to experience, create and run all characters who aren't Heroes, and oversee the application of the rules. That's a lot to handle, so try to help your GM whenever you can. If they're struggling to keep everyone's attention focused on the game, help them get the other players on track. If your GM is flipping through the rules, ask if you can help. Maybe you know where to find whatever it is they need. If your GM seems unsure about how to handle a situation, throw out some suggestions. In short, try to make life easier for the poor soul.

## IMAGINE

Roleplaying is an exercise in make-believe. If you use your imagination, it can take you anywhere you want to go and let you do anything you want to do. If you don't, it will bore you to tears. Imagination is crucial when roleplaying. Unlike video games, which display imaginary worlds, roleplaying games *suggest* them. Just like when you're reading a book, many of the details are up to you. Always use your imagination and try to picture what's happening in the game world while roleplaying. Otherwise, the experience becomes nothing more than a few hours spent rolling dice and doing basic math.

## PARTICIPATE

Your GM can't be expected to do everything. It's up to you to participate. Don't sit there silently waiting for someone to tell you what to do. Speak up and interact with the GM and the other players. Play your Hero, suggest solutions to whatever problems your GM throws at you, and get into the game. If you're new to the game (or the hobby, for that matter), don't worry about the rules; your GM and fellow players are there to help you. Be an active participant, not a passive observer. However, be careful not to go too far and hog the spotlight or the GM's attention. Let other players, especially new ones, play their Heroes, come up with ideas, and participate in the game as well.

## ROLEPLAY

It's called a *roleplaying* game for a reason. The whole point of the game is to pretend to be someone else, so go for it. Get into your Hero's head and try to act, think, and even talk like that imaginary person. The beauty of roleplaying is that it lets you step into someone else's shoes, someone who may be very different from you. Take the opportunity and play that other person to the hilt, even if that leads you to do or say things you never would. That's what this is all about.

## SAVOR CHALLENGES

Your GM is supposed to challenge you. When things get tough, don't get so frustrated that you just toss your hands in the air and concede defeat. Don't get mad at your GM, even if things look bleak or you find yourself out of ideas. Your GM isn't trying to make your life miserable (well, probably not). They're just trying to create an exciting story, which means it can't be a cakewalk. Sometimes things are going to look bad for the Heroes. Those moments are priceless. When that happens, savor the tension. Don't lose sight of the fact that it's just a game, don't take things personally, and don't forget that the actual goal of the game is to have a good time with your friends.



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